

Simulation without a Simulator?

Resolved Description, Support Hierarchy, and Structural Asymmetry

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Abstract

Simulation arguments typically presuppose a symmetric hierarchy: an upstream process that enacts a world, and an inhabitant who occupies it, where both levels involve something like an operative standpoint. This paper argues that this symmetry is not structurally required. Drawing on a minimal distinction between compressed and resolved descriptions — a distinction that tracks the functional separability of model and selection roles established by algorithmic information theory — we develop a no-entailment result: support-dependence does not entail upstream resolution. A resolved internal standpoint may depend, as a condition of its reachability, on antecedent support conditions — including, in the simulation case, what would ordinarily be called a simulator — without those conditions themselves constituting any resolved standpoint. The standard picture of simulation as a relation between two resolved levels is therefore a special case rather than a structural requirement. The paper does not adjudicate between competing positions in the simulation literature; it isolates a specific structural assumption that those discussions tend to share and shows that the assumption is not entailed by the support structure that simulation arguments invoke. The general theory of compressed and resolved descriptions on which the argument draws is developed in companion work [7]; the present paper is a focused application to simulation arguments specifically.

Keywords: simulation argument; support hierarchy; resolution hierarchy; structural asymmetry; compressed and resolved descriptions; algorithmic information theory; Everettian quantum mechanics; self-locating belief

1 Introduction

Simulation arguments typically proceed by contrasting the world as encountered from within with some upstream process, substrate, or agency responsible for making that world operative [2, 3]. The contrast is usually framed as a relation between at least two occupied levels: a simulated world inhabited by its occupants, and a simulating level from which those occupants' conditions are enacted. Whatever else is disputed in this literature, the structural picture tends to be held constant — simulation is a relation between perspectives, and the question is about their arrangement and relative status.

This paper questions that structural picture. It does not argue that simulations are impossible, nor that the simulation hypothesis is false. Its target is narrower: the assumption that if a simulation relation obtains, there must be a further resolved standpoint — the simulator's —

from which the generative conditions of the simulated world are encountered as operative. This assumption, the paper argues, is not structurally required.

The argument draws on a minimal distinction between two kinds of description. A *compressed* description specifies an admissible space of configurations without selecting any one of them as operative. A *resolved* description contains the additional information that singles out one configuration as operative from within the description. The paper’s structural claim is that a resolved internal standpoint may depend, as a condition of its reachability, on an antecedent support route that includes upstream structure — including, in the simulation case, what would ordinarily be described as a simulator — without that upstream structure itself constituting any resolved standpoint. The support relation obtains; the perspective relation need not. Throughout the paper, “simulator” is used in a role-functional sense: it denotes whatever upstream structure occupies the support role ordinarily attributed to a simulator — the condition or process through which the internal standpoint becomes reachable. Nothing in that role alone entails that the upstream structure is itself agentive, intentional, or resolved from its own standpoint. The compressed/resolved distinction is introduced in the form needed for the present argument in Section 2; its general theory and its further structural consequences are developed in companion work [7].

One way to make the structural point vivid is to consider what it is to occupy the terminus of a dependency chain. From that position, the chain appears to recede upward through a series of conditions on which the terminus depends. The internal form of occupying a resolved standpoint can make the antecedent chain appear fixed, operative, and explanatory. In simulation contexts, this can encourage the further picture of a chain populated by perspectives looking back down. But this is a structural consequence of being at the resolved end, not a claim about what the chain actually contains. Nothing in the dependency relation itself requires that any other link in the chain was ever occupied from within. Moreover, the resolved standpoint cannot verify from within whether the projected hierarchy corresponds to anything independently resolved: any attempt to represent the upstream as fully grounded would itself introduce further selection information, extending the projected chain rather than closing it [7]. The support structure may be fully instantiated without the perspective hierarchy that the resolved standpoint’s situation can suggest.

The argument is therefore a no-entailment result. From the fact that an internal standpoint depends on upstream support conditions, it does not follow that those support conditions are themselves resolved from any standpoint. The paper is not arguing against simulation, against the existence of upstream resolved perspectives, or against any particular position in the simulation literature; it is showing that a specific structural inference — from support-dependence to upstream resolution — is not licensed.

The simulation case is the most philosophically vivid instance of this asymmetry because existing arguments are so firmly built around the two-perspectives picture. The paper engages the existing literature on simulation, indexicality, and self-location [1, 10, 9] without attempting to adjudicate between competing positions within it. Its contribution is to isolate and examine an assumption that those discussions tend to share, and to show that the assumption is not entailed by the support structure that simulation arguments actually invoke. The Everettian material discussed later in the paper [5, 14, 11, 8, 4] is used to exhibit a familiar context in which a structurally similar asymmetry arises and is seriously debated, and should not be read as importing any substantive commitment to that interpretation.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 introduces the compressed/resolved distinction, grounds it in algorithmic information theory, and defines the support and resolution hierarchies. Section 3 states the central proposition and establishes it through a branching model. Section 4 applies the result to simulation arguments and identifies the specific assumption that fails.

Section 5 develops the Everettian parallel as evidence that the structural question is taken seriously in the foundations of physics. The final sections draw out consequences, mark scope, and state non-claims.

2 Two Kinds of Description

The argument of this paper depends on a minimal distinction between two forms of description. The distinction is introduced here in the form sufficient for the paper’s purposes; its general theory and its further structural consequences are developed in companion work [7].

The Distinction

Definition 1 (Compressed description). *A compressed description specifies an admissible space of possible configurations, histories, or outcomes without selecting any one of them as operative from within the description.*

Definition 2 (Resolved description). *A resolved description specifies not only an admissible space, but also the information that singles out one element, path, or configuration as operative from within the description.*

A compressed description can be complete in one sense while remaining non-indexical in another: it may fully specify the lawful or structural space within which outcomes are admissible, yet still fail to answer the question “which one is this?” A resolved description, by contrast, contains an internal asymmetry: one possibility is presented as the operative case. It makes available the form “this one” rather than only “one of these.”

Grounding the Distinction

The distinction between compressed and resolved descriptions is not stipulated for the purposes of this paper. It tracks a formally identifiable separation in the algorithmic analysis of individual informational objects.

The Kolmogorov structure function, developed by Vereshchagin and Vitányi [13] and grounded in results by Gács, Tromp, and Vitányi [6], provides a decomposition of any individual data string into two formally separable components: a model description, which specifies the structural regularity of the string — its generative constraints and admissible space — and a data-to-model code, which specifies only the index of the particular string within the model, that is, the selection information that identifies this string rather than any other consistent with the same model.

The relevant point for present purposes is that algorithmic statistics makes formally precise a separation between information that specifies a model or admissible set and information that identifies a particular element within that set. While the exact formal decomposition depends on the usual parameters of algorithmic information theory — model class, complexity bound, choice of universal machine up to constants — the functional separation between model-specification and data-to-model selection is robustly available. The relevant question, for present purposes, is whether a description’s role is exhausted by admissible-space specification, or whether it also contributes element-identifying information relative to that space. This distinction is not merely a matter of verbal presentation: it tracks whether information beyond the model is doing selection work [6]. The present paper relies on this functional separation rather than on any claim that the same formal machinery transfers unchanged to every descriptive setting considered here.

A compressed description corresponds to an object whose role is exhausted by admissible-space specification. A resolved description corresponds to an object whose content also contributes element-identifying information — information that does selection work relative to the admissible space, identifying one element as the operative case. These are, in their roles, mutually exclusive classes. A single description cannot simultaneously have its role exhausted by admissible-space specification and contribute element-identifying selection work; either the description is doing selection work beyond what is required to specify the admissible space, or it is not. No single description can simultaneously specify an admissible space without privileging any element and contain the information that singles out one element as operative. The mutual exclusivity is not a consequence of how the definitions are framed. It follows from the functional separability of model and selection roles that algorithmic statistics identifies.

The structure function decomposition is defined for finite binary strings, but the functional separation it identifies — between the specification of an admissible space and the identification of a particular element within it — applies wherever descriptions have both structural and selective content. The present paper’s claims rest on this functional separation, not on the string formalism itself. The companion paper [7] develops the scope of this analogy in detail; the present paper relies only on its application to the descriptions considered here.

A Note on Resolution

Throughout this paper, describing one element as “operative” or “selected” is used in a structural sense: it denotes the presence of selection information within a description, identifying one element within a descriptive framework. This is not a claim about what is actual in any interpretation-independent sense, nor does it require any agent act or relational designation. Resolution is an informational fact about what a description contains, not a claim about who or what performed the selection. This matters for what follows: the reason a simulation node need not be resolved is not that it lacks a perspective-bearing agent, but that, as a branching condition in the generative rule, it carries no selection residual — that is, in the framing of the previous subsection, its role is exhausted by admissible-space specification and it contributes no element-identifying information of its own. Its entire informational content is structural. It is compressed by virtue of what it contains.

The Support and Resolution Hierarchies

With the distinction in place, two further terms can be introduced that will be needed in what follows.

The *support hierarchy* of a resolved standpoint is the set of upstream conditions on which that standpoint depends as conditions of its reachability. These conditions may include physical substrate, generative rules, antecedent branching routes, or, in the simulation case, whatever upstream structure makes the internal standpoint reachable. The support hierarchy is defined by the dependency relation alone. It says nothing, by itself, about whether any element within it is resolved.

The *resolution hierarchy* of a resolved standpoint is the set of standpoints, if any, that are themselves resolved and on which the given standpoint depends. A standpoint belongs to the resolution hierarchy only if it constitutes an occupied perspective in the sense of the resolved description above — only if, that is, it contains the information that singles out one configuration as operative from within.

These two hierarchies can coincide. If every element of the support hierarchy is itself a resolved standpoint, then the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy are the same. But they need not coincide. An element may belong to the support hierarchy — may be a

genuine condition of the internal standpoint’s reachability — without belonging to the resolution hierarchy.

A clarification at this point will matter for what follows. Membership in the support hierarchy is route-relative: an element belongs to the support hierarchy of a particular resolved standpoint by virtue of being a condition of that standpoint’s reachability. But being on the route to a resolved standpoint is not the same as being itself a resolved standpoint. A condition can be route-relative to a resolved address while contributing nothing of its own to the resolution hierarchy — it functions as support content rather than as an occupied perspective. The distinction can be put crisply: being part of the address route is not the same as being an addressed endpoint. Equivalently, a support condition may be selected-relative-to a terminal address without being resolved-from-itself. This distinction is what allows the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy to come apart.

Whether the two hierarchies coincide in any particular case is a structural question; the remainder of this paper argues that simulation arguments have tended to assume coincidence where the structure does not require it.

Illustrative Example: The Telephone Number

A short example helps fix the distinction before the more technical model of Section 3. A numbering scheme specifies the admissible form of valid addresses without selecting any one of them as operative. Such a scheme may also require that valid addresses consist of strings of a certain length and form: a partial sequence may then be route-relevant — necessary for reaching a completed number — without itself constituting a valid address. A particular phone number identifies one valid location within that space — it is a resolved description within the admissible space the scheme defines. The route by which the number becomes reachable is a genuine support condition of the call, but it occupies no resolved standpoint of its own. It is present in the support hierarchy; it was never present in the resolution hierarchy.

The telephone case does not model the full simulation relation, since a call is indexed at both ends. Its role is narrower: it shows that a structure may belong essentially to the support hierarchy of a resolved connection without itself constituting any resolved standpoint. The branching model of Section 3 extends this point: it shows that the upstream support route of a resolved standpoint need not include any further resolved standpoint at all.

3 The Structural Result

This section establishes the paper’s central structural claim. The order of exposition is: the branching model that the argument relies on, then the proposition itself, then the argument that the proposition follows from the model together with the mutual exclusivity established in Section 2.

The Branching Model

Consider a finite branching structure generated by the following rules:

1. At each node, the structure branches into two admissible continuations, labelled A and B .
2. Each branching choice is retained, so that after n branchings a location is identified by a string of length n over $\{A, B\}$.
3. A valid address is any such string of fixed length 7.

4. Distinct addresses are mutually inaccessible from within the model: no address contains an internal route to any other address.

The generative rule defines an admissible branching space without selecting any one address as operative. In the terminology of Section 2, it is a compressed description — its informational content is fully exhausted by the model component, with zero selection residual. A particular occupied address such as

$$A, B, A, A, B, A, B$$

is a resolved description. It contains information not present in the generative rule itself: which admissible route is operative from within the structure.

Now suppose that some seventh-level addresses are reachable only through a particular fourth-level transition — a specific branching condition on specific routes — that functions, relative to those addresses, as a simulation-enabling condition. We will refer to this simulation-enabling transition, for convenience, as the *simulation node*. The simulation node is therefore a condition of the reachability of any such address — without it, those addresses are not reachable. It belongs to the support hierarchy of any resolved standpoint that depends on it.

But the simulation node appears in the structure as part of the generative rule — as one of the branching conditions that determines which addresses are admissible — rather than as an occupied address within the structure. Considered as an element of the generative rule, it carries no selection residual. Its entire informational content is structural.

The Proposition

Proposition 1. *A resolved internal standpoint may depend, as a condition of its reachability, on an antecedent support route that includes upstream structure without that upstream structure itself constituting any resolved standpoint. The support relation and the resolution relation are therefore structurally independent — the obtaining of the former does not require the obtaining of the latter. In particular, what functions as a simulator in the support route of a resolved standpoint need not itself be resolved from any standpoint at all. Symmetry between the simulated and simulating levels is not a structural requirement of the simulation relation.*

The proposition is the paper’s central structural claim. The companion paper [7] establishes the same structural independence at full generality and as a consequence of the Hierarchical Asymmetry developed there. The present argument gives the result for the simulation case directly, drawing on the branching model just established and the mutual exclusivity of compressed and resolved descriptions argued in Section 2.

The Argument

The proposition requires only that there exists a coherent structural description in which the support relation obtains at an upstream level without any resolved standpoint obtaining there. The branching model just established provides exactly this.

In that model, the simulation node belongs to the support hierarchy of any seventh-level address whose route passes through it: it is a genuine condition of that address’s reachability. It may even lie on the selected route to a particular resolved address. But being on the selected route is not the same as being itself a resolved standpoint, as established in Section 2. The simulation node is, considered as an element of the generative rule, a compressed description in the sense established there — its informational content is fully exhausted by the model component, with zero selection residual. By the mutual exclusivity of compressed and resolved

descriptions, it is therefore not a resolved description. It is present in the support hierarchy; it is absent from the resolution hierarchy.

This is a coherent structural description. The simulation node’s status as a branching condition rather than an occupied location is not a stipulation but a consequence of what it contains. It is not a limiting case or a special exception: it is simply what the structure looks like when the support route includes conditions that were never themselves resolved from within. The mutual exclusivity that makes the node compressed-and-not-resolved is established by the functional separability of model and selection roles argued in Section 2, not by anything special about the branching model itself; the model is the vehicle by which the structural claim becomes visible, not its support.

The proposition follows. The support relation obtains at the upstream level — the simulation node is a genuine condition of the internal standpoint’s reachability — while the resolution relation does not, because the node contains no selection information. Symmetry between the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy is not a structural requirement of the simulation relation. It may obtain in some cases, but it is not entailed by the support relation itself.

From within the occupied address, the antecedent route — including the simulation node — is not encountered as merely one admissible possibility among others. It belongs to the support route relative to which that internal location is reachable at all. In simulation contexts, this fixed support relation may be interpreted as though it required an upstream perspective that enacted it. But the model shows that this interpretation is not structurally forced: the same support relation is consistent with a hierarchy that contains no further resolved standpoints. The simulation node was never occupied. It was a branching condition, not a perspective.

4 Application to Simulation Arguments

Simulation arguments in their canonical forms proceed by asking whether the conditions of one’s world are consistent with their having been generated or enacted by an upstream computational or intentional process [2, 3]. The arguments vary considerably in their conclusions and commitments, but they tend to share a structural assumption that has not been made explicit as a structural target of examination in its own right.

The assumption is this: if a simulation relation obtains, there exists at least one further resolved standpoint — the simulator’s — from which the generative conditions of the simulated world are encountered as operative. Simulation, on this picture, is a relation between two occupied perspectives. The simulated world is inhabited from within; the simulating level is inhabited from without, by an agent or process that encounters the simulation as its own enacted product.

This assumption is rarely stated because it rarely needs to be. It is built into the framing of simulation arguments at a level prior to their specific claims. Bostrom’s trilemma [2] is formulated in terms of civilisations running simulations — entities that occupy perspectives and make computational choices. Chalmers’ response [3] engages the metaphysical status of simulated worlds but retains the picture of a simulating level that is itself operative in the relevant sense. The assumption of coincidence between the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy is, in this literature, the water the arguments swim in.

Adjacent discussions have approached related questions from different directions. Functional accounts of mind and substrate neutrality bear on whether a simulating process needs to be construed as a perspective-bearing agent at all, or whether it can be a purely functional process [3]. Non-intentional treatments of simulation as a causal-structural relation [12] suggest that the intentional framing of simulation arguments is not mandatory even within the philosophy of science literature. What these discussions do not isolate is the specific structural question

this paper examines: whether the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy of a resolved internal standpoint must coincide, and what follows if they need not. The present paper’s contribution is not to deny that simulators can be perspective-bearing agents, nor to show that functional or structural accounts of simulation are preferable. It is to show that the coincidence of the two hierarchies is not entailed by the support structure that simulation arguments invoke, and that this structural independence has not been made explicit as a target of examination in its own right.

The structural result of Section 3 shows that the symmetry assumption is not required. The support relation and the resolution relation are independent. What functions as a simulator in the support route of a resolved standpoint need not itself constitute a resolved standpoint. The simulating level may be present in the support hierarchy — as a genuine condition of the internal standpoint’s reachability — while being absent from the resolution hierarchy entirely. There need be no perspective from which the simulation is encountered as operative.

This does not show that the assumption is false in any particular case. A simulator may well occupy a resolved standpoint of its own. The point is that this is a contingent feature of specific simulation scenarios, not a structural requirement of the simulation relation itself. The symmetric picture — two resolved perspectives, one containing the other — is a special case. The asymmetric picture — a resolved internal standpoint whose support route includes conditions that were never themselves resolved — is equally coherent and has not been isolated as a structural target of examination in its own right.

The philosophical consequence is precise. Internal appearances of having been generated, selected, or enacted from above are not, by themselves, evidence that the upstream source occupies a resolved standpoint. Those appearances are consistent with a support hierarchy that contains no further resolved standpoints at all. To inhabit a resolved world is already to encounter one’s conditions as fixed and operative. But the chain of dependencies on which that world rests need not be populated by perspectives at any other point. The resolved standpoint may be the only perspective the chain ever contained.

5 The Everettian Parallel

The structural asymmetry developed in this paper — a resolved internal standpoint depending on upstream support conditions that are not themselves resolved from any standpoint — may appear to be an exotic or artificially constructed possibility. The Everettian picture of quantum mechanics provides an independently motivated context in which a structurally similar asymmetry is already at work, and already the subject of serious theoretical attention. The role of this section is illustrative rather than confirmatory: the Everettian case shows that the asymmetry between support and resolution hierarchies is not a curiosity invented for the purposes of this argument, but a structural feature that arises naturally within one of the most carefully developed approaches in the foundations of quantum mechanics.

In Everettian formulations, the universal wavefunction evolves globally without privileging any one outcome as the uniquely actual one in the collapse sense [5, 14]. It does not, from within, single out one configuration as operative. In the terminology of this paper, the universal wavefunction plays a compressed role with respect to branch-local outcomes: it specifies the global structure without containing the kind of branch-relative selection information that would identify one local outcome as uniquely operative. Yet any observer within a particular branch encounters something structurally analogous to a resolved description — a determinate outcome whose internal conditions appear fixed and operative. The universal wavefunction, so construed, belongs to the support hierarchy of every local resolved outcome — it is a genuine condition of the branch’s reachability — while not itself supplying the kind of branch-relative

selection information that would make one outcome uniquely operative from any standpoint. The companion paper [7] develops this mapping in full; the present section draws on it only to locate the Everettian debate within the same structural question this paper examines in the simulation context.

Sebens and Carroll argue that branch-local observers can assign self-locating probabilities precisely because the global wavefunction does not resolve their location for them [11]. Kent objects that it is unclear whether self-locating uncertainty in the universal wavefunction is even a coherent notion [8]. Dawid and Friederich argue that the epistemic separability principle Sebens and Carroll invoke cannot be independently motivated and ultimately presupposes what it is meant to derive [4]. These critics are not endorsing the asymmetry; they are raising difficulties with it. But the difficulties they raise are precisely difficulties about whether local resolution can be coherently grounded without global resolution — which is exactly the structural question this paper is examining in the simulation context.

The Everettian debate therefore serves a specific and limited function here. It shows that the question of whether a resolved internal standpoint can depend on support conditions that are not themselves resolved is not a question this paper invented. It is a question that arises independently within a major research programme in the foundations of physics, and that serious theorists on multiple sides take to be both meaningful and unresolved. That is sufficient for the present paper’s purposes. The simulation case inherits neither the difficulties nor the achievements of the Everettian debate. It stands or falls on the structural argument of Section 3.

The analogy should not be overstated in either direction. The paper does not claim that Everettian quantum mechanics entails the proposition, nor that the proposition requires Everett to be true. Equally, it does not claim that the difficulties Kent and Dawid–Friederich raise for the Everettian case transfer to the simulation case. The structural setting differs. The point of contact is narrow: both cases involve a resolved internal standpoint whose support conditions are globally unresolved, and both cases generate serious theoretical questions about whether and how that asymmetry can be sustained. The present paper addresses those questions in the simulation setting through the structural argument of the preceding sections.

6 Consequences and Generalisation

Once the structural point is isolated, its consequences extend beyond the simulation hypothesis in its narrow contemporary form. The result applies more generally wherever one moves from the internal operativity of a resolved standpoint to the claim that there must exist a higher-level resolved source that made it so.

The general lesson is that the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy are independent, and that the internal appearance of having been enacted from above does not settle the question of whether the upstream source was itself resolved. A world may bear all the marks of having been selected, fixed, or made operative from above while those marks arise solely from the fact that it is described from within a resolved standpoint.

This has a broader philosophical consequence. It suggests that some forms of apparent derivation from a higher level may be structural projections rather than ontological disclosures. To inhabit a resolved world is already to encounter one’s conditions as fixed and operative. The temptation to populate the upstream support structure with resolved perspectives may therefore reflect a misreading of what resolution itself contributes — and crucially, no internal representational act available to a resolved standpoint can settle the question, since any attempt to represent the containing hierarchy as fully grounded extends the projected presupposition rather than closing it [7].

Nothing in this requires denying that higher-level resolved structures can exist. The point

is one of structural independence. Even if there is, in some cases, a genuine upstream resolved selector, the internal appearance of selection is insufficient by itself to establish that fact. The same appearance may occur where the containing level is globally unresolved.

A further question, beyond the scope of the present paper, concerns the internal structure of the upward chain that any resolved standpoint projects from its own perspective. The companion paper notes that the structure of this chain may be partition-relative: what counts as a “level” in the projected hierarchy depends on how the admissible space is decomposed, and different decompositions of the same underlying structure may produce different chain geometries for the same resolution [7]. For simulation arguments specifically, this means that the question of how many “levels” separate a simulated world from its support conditions, and what relationships obtain between those levels, may itself be partition-relative. The present paper does not pursue that question; it is noted here only because it qualifies any attempt to extract a more precise architecture of the upstream support structure from the structural argument given here.

7 Scope, Non-Claims, and Exit Conditions

The thesis of this paper is structural and limited. The following states precisely what it does and does not establish.

The paper does not claim that simulated realities are impossible, that simulators are absent, or that the asymmetric case is more common or probable than the symmetric one. A world could still be externally generated, computationally hosted, or dependent on an upstream process that itself occupies a resolved standpoint. A simulator may genuinely figure in the support route of a resolved internal standpoint while also occupying a resolved standpoint of its own. The symmetric case — in which the support hierarchy and the resolution hierarchy coincide — may obtain in specific instances. The paper claims only that coincidence is not structurally required, and that the presence of the support relation does not entail the presence of the resolution relation at the upstream level. No frequency claim is made. The result is a structural possibility claim: the asymmetry is coherent, non-degenerate, and arises naturally within independently motivated theoretical contexts. Whether it obtains in any particular case is a further question the paper does not address.

The paper does not attempt to derive a specific physical theory or to settle disputes in the interpretation of quantum mechanics. The Everettian material is used because it provides an independently motivated context in which a structurally similar asymmetry is already at work and already seriously debated. It does not commit the paper to Everettian quantum mechanics, and the paper’s structural argument does not depend on that interpretation being correct or the Everettian debate being resolved in any particular direction.

The paper does not deny the importance of indexicality, self-location, or observer-relative description. On the contrary, it depends on the insight that resolved and compressed descriptions have genuinely different structural consequences [10, 9]. What it resists is the assumption that the support hierarchy of a resolved standpoint must itself be populated by resolved standpoints.

The paper does not pursue the question of whether the projected upward chain has partition-relative internal structure. That question is framed in the companion work [7] but not closed there, and it is not closed here. The present paper’s structural argument does not depend on its resolution.

The paper reaches its intended stopping point once the following result is secured: the support relation and the resolution relation are structurally independent in the simulation case, symmetry between them is not required by the simulation relation, and a resolved internal standpoint may be the only perspective its support chain ever contained. Beyond that point,

further claims about what reality ultimately is would require additional premises not supplied here.

8 Conclusion

This paper has argued for a structural asymmetry that simulation arguments have not adequately considered. A resolved internal standpoint may depend, as a condition of its reachability, on an antecedent support route that includes upstream conditions — including, in the simulation case, what would ordinarily be described as a simulator — without those upstream conditions themselves constituting any resolved standpoint. The support relation and the resolution relation are independent. Symmetry between them is not a structural requirement of the simulation relation.

The argument is, in this sense, a no-entailment result. From the fact that an internal standpoint depends on upstream support conditions, it does not follow that those conditions are themselves resolved from any standpoint. The branching model makes this concrete: a resolved address depends on the generative conditions that make it reachable, including any simulation node through which its support route passes; but that node, considered as an element of the generative rule, carries no selection residual and is therefore not a resolved description. It is present in the support hierarchy without being present in the resolution hierarchy. It was never resolved from any standpoint at all.

For simulation arguments specifically, this means that the standard symmetric picture — two resolved levels, one containing the other — is a special case rather than a structural requirement. Internal appearances of having been generated or enacted from above are consistent with a support hierarchy that contains no further resolved standpoints. The chain of dependencies on which a resolved world rests need not be populated by perspectives at any other point. A world may be fully inhabited from within a resolved standpoint while the conditions that make that standpoint reachable were never resolved from any standpoint whatsoever. The paper has not shown that this is always or typically the case. It has shown that it is a coherent structural possibility — and that the standard simulation picture, which assumes otherwise, requires justification that the structure does not automatically supply. A structurally similar asymmetry is independently at issue in the Everettian foundations of physics [11, 8, 4], where it is the subject of live and unresolved debate; the present paper addresses the structural question in the simulation setting through independent argument.

The resolved standpoint may be the only perspective the chain ever contained.

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